

representation of communities and regions. Former transport minister Surupsinh Naik, who resigned from the cabinet in May 2006 following a month-long imprisonment charge, has returned. An influential Adivasi leader from Nandurbar, Naik was inducted only to counter the NCP's growing influence in the northern region. The Congress lost to the NCP in the recent Zilla Parishad elections held there. Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Ramdas Kadam says: "Governance will not change by changing faces. The Government has only played up caste differences and divided portfolios to keep everyone happy."

The other region that finds representation in the new government is Marathwada, which has a strong OBC lobby that is loyal to the Shiv Sena. Apart from a Maratha chief minister, the region now has four other ministers—Rajesh Tope, who has a cabinet berth, Suresh Warpudkar, Rajendra Shingane and Vimal Mundada. "Apart from the saffron parties, the BSP also made a dent in the Congress-NCP votes in these regions. Offering ministerial berths to their representatives is an



NARAYAN RANE

RANE IS LEFT WITH FEW CHOICES. HE IS WORKING TO WEAN AWAY SOME MLAS TO SPLIT THE CONGRESS, FORM A NEW PARTY BEFORE THE LOK SABHA POLLS AND TIE UP WITH RAJ THACKERAY'S PARTY.

attempt to wean the voters away from these parties," says political scientist Venkatesh Kumar.

Chavan has also tried to put a crisis management system in place for non-performing ministries. Higher and medical education, which suffered under Dilip Walse Patil, has now been handed over to Rajesh Tope. A former minister of state for urban development, Tope will have to address issues of autonomy to colleges, revisit the appointment of doctors on a per-hour basis and revamp the archaic Maharashtra Universities' Act. The NCP also has inducted new faces in its bid to move away from its western Maharashtra-dominated image. Vidarbha, a traditional Congress stronghold, is now a BJP-dominated region. By bringing in Bhandara MLA Nana Panchbudhe and Nagpur's Ramesh Bang, the NCP is trying to make inroads into this area. The Congress too is not far behind. Wadettiwar has been sworn in as a minister of state to appease the OBC votebase in Vidarbha.

Given the faux pas of the previous chief minister and his deputy, the home portfolio has been entrusted with Jayant Patil. Son of Congressman Rajarambapu Patil, the 46-year-old former finance minister is the urbane and educated face of the NCP, and was credited with dealing with finances with a tight fist. With the terror investigations underway, Patil has to modernise the force, usher in reforms and improve security measures.

A large section of the Cabinet is nothing more than old faces reshuffled. The team includes 26 cabinet ministers (17 from NCP, seven from Congress and two Independents) and 13 ministers of state. Chavan has dropped education minister Vasant Purke, Anil Deshmukh (PWD), Satish Chaturvedi (textiles) and Baba Siddiqui (civil supplies), inducted eight new faces and brought back two old-timers. The key ministries, however, remain with the heavyweights, some of whom have proved to be non-performers. The new team may not give Maharashtra better governance but it certainly bodes well for the Congress-NCP's political future in the forthcoming elections. ■

KEY Appointments



DEPUTY CM AND PWD

Chhagan Bhujbal (NCP)

CONSTITUENCY: Yeola, Nashik

AGE: 61

With his four years of experience as the home minister and deputy chief minister till 2003, Bhujbal is expected to be a strong force in the current DF Government



HOME

Jayant Patil (NCP)

CONSTITUENCY: Walwa, Sangli

AGE: 46

The former finance minister has the responsibility of reviving a demoralised police force, implementing reforms and improving security in India's financial capital



ENERGY

Sunil Tatkare (NCP)

CONSTITUENCY: Mangaon

AGE: 53

The low-profile former food and civil supplies minister will now have to source power from the Centre and invite private-public partnership in energy generation projects